



LibreOffice
The Document Foundation

The open source challenger

to what they're used to. Similarly, the replacement office suite's support for proprietary formats is also a must. More so in a business environment that will be exchanging files with users of proprietary office suites.

One of the the most powerful and popular suites in this regard is LibreOffice, which comes pre-installed with most Linux-based systems today. Started off by a breakaway team from the OpenOffice.org project, the progress that's been made by these groups of people in what is a relatively short time for desktop applications is remarkable. LibreOffice is one of the most comprehensive suites out there. Almost every LibreOffice app has easy-to-navigate wizards and templates to help you create all sorts of documents. To ease interoperability, the suite supports a large number of proprietary formats, from Microsoft 97 to Microsoft 2010, and can export files to PDF as well. It can automatically hook up with the default email client so that you can email documents from within the app. You can further extend the suite by adding extensions from the online catalogue. However, it's the bulkiest suite in the roundup and requires a well-stocked system to perform well. Although dependant on Java, it works flawlessly with the open source OpenJDK platform.

LibreOffice Writer has several wizards to help you get started with creating a document. It's also got a document converter for converting documents in Microsoft Word's legacy formats (.doc, .xls, and .ppt) into its open document equivalent. Writer lets you add blocks of text, called sections, which can then be protected against changes, be hidden, and converted back to normal text. It has pre-defined column layouts, and lets you create your own. It's also designed to ease working with long documents with features such as the navigator.

Calc has lots of wizards to help you use its advanced functions. It can also download templates from the LibreOffice template repository, and can pull in data from databases. It has an 'intelligent sum' button that inserts a sum function or sub-total automatically. Unlike other apps in the